Federico Lenzi

Curriculum Vitae — October 2026

Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University
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RESEARCH FIELDS

Primary: Financial Intermediation, Corporate Finance.
Secondary: Entrepreneurial Finance, FinTech & AI.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Finance, Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University *2021 – Expected 2027*
Committee: Efraim Benmelech (Chair), Michael J. Fishman, Sean Higgins, Filippo Mezzanotti, Jacopo Ponticelli, Regina Wittenberg Moerman.

M.Sc. in Economics, University of Bologna *2017 – 2019*
110/110 cum laude.

B.Sc. in Business and Administration, University of Salerno *2014 – 2017*
110/110 cum laude.

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Advertising versus Screening? Online-collected data in lending markets"

Job Market Paper

Abstract: As mortgage shopping moves online, lenders gain data on borrowers' search and browsing activity. These data improve screening, lower rates, and expand credit. But they also support targeted advertising that reduces comparison shopping and raises markups. Which force dominates determines who benefits from online data. I exploit the staggered adoption of state privacy laws limiting these uses, comparing borrowers at the same lender across states. Restricting data lowers mortgage rates by 14 basis points at advertising-reliant lenders: lower markups outweigh weaker screening. Consistent with weaker screening, approval rates fall one percentage point for credit scores below 750 and rise half a point above it. Consistent with weaker targeting, paid-search clicks fall 7% at lenders using advertising-platform data. A search model shows that privacy shifts surplus from lenders to borrowers but reduces total surplus because search becomes costlier and screening weaker. In digital lending, data-use rules shape search and credit access.

WORKING PAPERS

"Escaping the Financing Trap: Bond Markets and the Dieselization of U.S. Railroads" (with E. Benmelech)

Systemic technologies require firms to replace much of their fixed-asset base, an investment that banks' limited capacity and equity investors' short horizons leave to bond markets. Yet bond financing itself depends on collateral becoming redeployable and salable, which requires broad adoption and standardized equipment. This interdependence can create a financing trap. Using newly digitized records, we show that the War Production Board broke this trap during U.S. railroads' dieselization: favoring diesel orders broadened adoption, and concentrating production at General Motors standardized locomotives.

"Downside-Risk Sharing" (with L. Rossi)

Revise and Resubmit at the European Economic Review

We develop a new measure of downside-risk sharing and show that U.S. federal taxes and transfers absorb about 79% of downside income risk, versus roughly 15% in conventional estimates.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

"Strategic Search Frictions in the AI Age"

I study whether lenders respond to AI comparison tools by making their offers harder to compare.

"Pooling Collateral: Helping or Trapping SMEs?" (with T. Chen and R. Wittenberg Moerman)

We study whether pooling collateral expands SMEs' access to credit at the cost of innovative investments.

"Guaranteed Innovation?" (with G. Cascarino)

Using newly digitized Italian data, we study when public loan guarantees help innovative firms attract venture capital and when they crowd it out.

PUBLICATIONS

"Subnational Income Convergence and the COVID-19 Pandemic"

with I. Del Barco, A. M. Choudhary, I. A. Haqqani, and N. Limodio. ***World Bank Economic Review***, 38(2), 421–448, 2024.

"What Reduces Frictions in Trade Finance? The Role of Banks, Relationships, and Policy"

with N. B. Adou and J.-W. Chien. ***PEDL Research Note*** (policy), CEPR, 2025.

GRANTS, HONORS, AND AWARDS

2026 AFA Ph.D. Student Travel Grant

2025 NBER Entrepreneurship Research Boot Camp — Travel Grant

2023 PEDL Grant MMW31, "Trade Finance and Firms' Response in Africa"

2021 Bonaldo Stringher Scholarship, Bank of Italy

2020 Bonaldo Stringher Scholarship, Bank of Italy

SEMINARS AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2027 AFA PhD Student Poster Session

2025 Chicago Entrepreneurship Workshop (Northwestern); Midwest Macroeconomics Spring Meeting (Kansas City Fed); Inter-Finance PhD Seminar.

2023 PEDL Young Scholars Matchmaking Workshop.

2022 Future Workshop, Bocconi University.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Kellogg School of Management — Teaching Assistant *2023 – 2026*

FINC-442: Financial Decisions (MBA, 2024–2026); *FINC-431: Finance II* (MBA, 2023–2024); *FINCX-940: Mergers and Acquisitions* (Executive MBA, 2023–2024).

University of Bologna — Teaching Assistant *2018 – 2019*

Corporate Finance (MBA).

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Kellogg School of Management — Research Assistant *2024 – 2026*

Supervisor: E. Benmelech.

Kellogg School of Management — Research Assistant *2022 – 2024*

Supervisor: F. Mezzanotti.

Bank of Italy — Summer Research Intern *2022*

Supervisor: L. Rossi.

London School of Economics — Overseas Consultant *2020*
Supervisor: R. Crescenzi.

Bocconi University — Pre-Doctoral Research Fellow *2019 – 2021*
Supervisor: N. Limodio.

University of Bologna — Research Assistant *2018 – 2019*
Supervisor: F. Barigozzi.

SKILLS

Languages: Italian (native), English (fluent).
Software: Python, R, Stata, SQL, Amazon Redshift, LaTeX, QGIS/ArcGIS.

REFERENCES

Prof. Efraim Benmelech (Chair)
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